

BHUTAN BIRDING & CULTURAL TOURS



Nestling in the heart of the Himalayas and protected by a complex geography of high mountains and deep valleys, Bhutan is rated as one of the 'top ten global hot spots' of the world. The intriguing yet profound tale of the transformation of this traditional kingdom, without losing out on its traditional norms and values while embarking on a modern course of development in the last half a century has been both a story of sustainable and progressive development in harmony with its natural environment.

Today, the proportion of land under forest cover is about 70% including shrub forest. An estimated 770 species of birds inhabit the unspoiled forests. The habitat of the avifauna is the spectacular epiphytic orchids, lichens ferns and mosses. It also harbors some of the most exotic species flora of the Eastern Himalayas with over 50 species of rhododendron along with an amazing variety of medicinal plants and magnolias. The valleys and even the roadside verges are home to colorful herbaceous perennials from mauve primulas to blue poppies and sweet-smelling shrubs. You can expect 400 species if your trip is conducted in Spring and about 300 species during other times.

The entire country is bisected by a well-maintained paved road, permitting relatively easy access to habitats from 150m to 3,750m. One of the important features of Bhutan is that birding, especially in mid to late spring (late March to mid-May) is good virtually everywhere. Unlike many parts of Asia, one is not obliged to seek out a park or reserve or remnant patch of 'good looking' habitat, since any stop, even in the midst farmland, exciting birds are visible.

The itinerary begins in Western Bhutan in the valley of Paro and is a perfect blend of faunal, floral and cultural diversity of this Himalayan Wonderland.

Facts and Figures

Land area : 38,394 square kilometers

Forest area	: 72.5 %
Altitude	: between 240metres and 7541metres above sea level
Inhabitants	: 700,000
Language	: official language “Dzongkha”, English widely spoken
Religion	: Vajrayana stream of Mahayana Buddhism (Also known as Tantric Buddhism)
Currency	: Ngultrum (equal to Indian Rupee)
Capital	: Thimphu
National Tree	: Cypress
National Bird	: Raven
National Flower	: Blue Poppy
National Sport	: Archery
National Animal	: Takin
Local time	: Six hours ahead of GMT and half an hour ahead of Indian Standard Time

BHUTAN BIRDING TOUR - 1

DAY 01 : ARRIVE PARO BY AIR & TRANSFER TO THIMPHU

The flight to Paro is one of the most spectacular in entire Himalayas. Whether flying along the Himalayan range from Kathmandu or over the foothills from Kolkatta, the journey offers fascinating views and an exciting descent into the Kingdom. Bhutan’s first gift as you disembark from the aircraft will be cool, clean fresh mountain air.

After immigration formalities and baggage collection, you will be met by our representative, and afterwards drive to Thimphu, the modern capital town of Bhutan. Later explore this beautiful upland valley. Relatively dry, the Thimphu valley is surrounded by fine stands of Blue Pine and temperate evergreen forests. The increasing human settlement has pushed birding spots at least 10 kilometers further and now the ideal areas for birding are around the stream near Motithang and in and around Begana and Cheri villages.

Depending on the flight timing , we will spend rest of the day birding around , some of the bird species in Thimphu include : *Blyth’s leaf Warbler, Black eared Kite, Blue whistling Thrush, Brown Parrotbil, Common Myna, Common Sandpiper, Common Kestrel, Eurasian Hobby, Fire tailed Sunbird, Greater short toed Lark, Golden spectacled Warbler, Grey backed Shrike, Hodgson’s Redstart, Laughing Thrush, Long tailed Minivet, Oriental Skylark, Oriental turtle Dove, Oriental white eye, Red rumped Swallow, Rufous Sibia, Ruddy breasted Crake, Spotted throated Yuhina, White browed Fulvetta, White capped Redstart, Yellow breasted Greenfinch, Brown Dipper, Black Eagle, Blyth’s Pipit, Black browed Tit, Coal Tit, Common Buzzard, Eurasian Hoopoe, Eurasian sparrow Hawk, Grey bush Chat, Grey Wagtail, Grey sided Bush Warbler, House Crow, Large billed Crow, Lemon rumped Warbler, Mountain hawk Eagle, Oriental honey Buzzard, Olive backed pipit, Plumbeous water Redstart, Rusty flanked Tree creeper, Red billed Chough, Rock Pigeon , Spotted laughing Thrush, Tickell’s leaf Warbler, Whiskered Yuhina, White throated laughing Thrush*

Time permitting again , we will visit some of Thimphu’s cultural sites like Trashichhodzong (This impressive fortress/monastery houses Secretariat building, the throne room of His Majesty, the King and various government offices. It is also the summer residence of Chief Abbot and central monk body) , and Memorial Chorten : The building of this landmark was envisaged by the third king, His Majesty Jigme

Dorji Wangchuck, as a monument to world peace and prosperity. Completed in 1974 after his untimely death, it is both a memorial to the Late King (“the Father of modern Bhutan”) and a monument to world peace. The paintings and statues inside the monument provide a deep insight into Buddhist philosophy.

Overnight at the hotel in Thimphu. (Altitude 2400m).

DAY 02 : THIMPHU

National Parks in Bhutan are not developed into a Tourist Destination , nor are there any wildlife options .

However, the following can be done on the second day in Thimphu :

After breakfast in the morning excursion to Tango Gompa : This monastery was founded by Lama Gyalwa Lhanangpa in the 12th century and the present building was built in the 15th century by the ‘Divine Madman’, Lama Drukpa Kunley. In 1616 Shabdrung Ngawang Namgyal visited Tango and meditated in a cave near the monastery. His meditation helped ensure the defeat of an invading Tibetan army. The head Lama, a descendent of Lama Drukpa Kunley presented the goemba to Shabdrung, who carved a sandalwood statue of Chenrezig which he installed in the monastery. The picturesque three-storey tower and several surrounding buildings were built in the 18th century by the eighth Desi, Druk Rabgye and Shabdrung Jigme Chhogyel added the golden roof in the 19th century. Situated north of Thimphu, one way it takes about 30 minutes drive and one hour walk through shaded rhododendron forests to reach the monastery.

Picnic Lunch .

After lunch stroll around a part of the Jigme Dorgi National Park .

Kingdom of Bhutan established its national park system to protect important ecosystems, and they have not been developed as tourist attraction. In many case people even won’t be aware that they are entering or leaving a national park or wild life sanctuary.

Jigme Dorji National Park : Is the largest protected area in the country, encompassing an area of 4,349 sq. km, covering the western parts of Paro, Thimphu and Punakha and almost entire area of Gasa district. The park is habitat of several endangered species including takin, blue sheep, snow leopard, musk deer, Himalayan black bear and red panda.

Later in the afternoon return back to the Hotel.

Dinner and Overnight at the hotel in Thimphu (Altitude 2400m).

DAY 03 : THIMPHU – GANGTEY (150 KM,5+ HRS)

Early morning embark on a Bird watching tour of Thimphu valley. Relatively dry, the Thimphu valley is surrounded by fine stands of Blue Pine and temperate evergreen forests. The increasing human settlement has pushed birding spots at least 10 kilometers further and now the ideal areas for birding are around the stream near Motithang and in and around Begana and Cheri villages.



Some of the bird species here include:

Blyth's leaf Warbler, Black eared Kite, Blue whistling Thrush, Brown Parrotbil, Common Myna, Common Sandpiper, Common Kestrel, Eurasian Hobby, Fire tailed Sunbird, Greater short toed Lark, Golden spectacled Warbler, Grey backed Shrike, Hodgson's Redstart, Laughing Thrush, Long tailed Minivet, Oriental Skylark, Oriental turtle Dove, Oriental white eye, Red rumped Swallow, Rufous Sibia, Ruddy breasted Crake, Spotted throated Yuhina, White browed Fulvetta, White capped Redstart, Yellow breasted Greenfinch, Brown Dipper, Black Eagle, Blyth's Pipit, Black browed Tit, Coal Tit, Common Buzzard, Eurasian Hoopoe, Eurasian sparrow Hawk, Grey bush Chat, Grey Wagtail, Grey sided Bush Warbler, Leomn rumped Warbler, Mountain hawk Eagle, Oriental honey Buzzard, Olive backed pipit, Plumbeous water Redstart, Rusty flanked Treecreeper, Red billed Chough, Rock Pigeon, Spotted laughing Thrush, Tickell's leaf Warbler, Whiskered Yuhina, White throated laughing Thrush.

Then drive to **Gangtey** across **Dochula pass (3,088m)** which offers most spectacular view over high peaks of eastern Himalayas.

After lunch stop en route, continue journey eastwards through Black Mountains region. The drive is relatively shorter and there are regular stops for birding and photography along the way. The road finally enters to forest of oak and rhododendron and then broad Phobjikha valley which is one of the few glacial valleys in Bhutan.

We can make a series of brief stops to scan the river channel en route. We may see **Pallas's Gull and Pallas's Fishing Eagle** here and add a number of other species to our Bhutanese

Evening explore fascinating Gangtey village.

Overnight at the hotel in Gangtey. (Altitude 3,000m)

DAY 04 : GANGTEY

The fascinating village of **Gangtey** sits on the ridge overlooking the large green expanse of the Phobjikha Valley. A large flock of Black-necked Cranes winters here, making this valley one of the most important wildlife reserves in the country.

We will check forest edges and explore some of the small patches of cultivation then continue our search in areas of productive forest near the end of our journey; here we will be looking for species such as:

Blood Pheasant, Satyr Tragopan and the majestic Himalayan Monal. Past highlights at this location have included ***Himalayan Honeyguide, Crested Kingfisher, Tibetan Serin, Short-billed Minivet and Rufous-bellied Bush-robin. Spotted Laughingthrush, Yellowish-bellied Bush-Warbler, Rusty-flanked Treecreeper, White-browed Bush Robin and White-winged Grosbeak***

Afternoon visit the **Gangtey Goemba**: Perched on a small hill that rises from the valley floor, the Gangtey Monastery is the only Nyingmapa monastery on the western side of the Black Mountain's and also the biggest Nyingmapa monastery in Bhutan. The Monastery is surrounded by a large village inhabited mainly by the families of the 140 Gomchens who take care of the Monastery.

Also visit **Black Neck Crane Information Centre**. Situated on the edge of the forest and wetland along the main road of Phobjikha valley, the black-necked crane information Centre has an observation room equipped with high power telescope and spotting scopes for catching the best view of the cranes. The centre also offers display information that outline the natural and cultural history of the area. There is a small gift shop, which sells handicrafts produced by the local people.

Overnight at the hotel in Gangtey. (Altitude 3,000m)

DAY 05 :GANGTEY

Day excursion to **Tangje Lhakhang** (3050 mtr)
(Distance 10-12 km approx, 4-5 hrs)

After leisurely breakfast at hotel we set out on a day hike toward the southeast direction through the vegetation of dwarf bamboos that adorns the Phobjikha valley where the rare species of Black Necked Cranes resides during winter (beginning of November till mid March). After an hour of easy hike we reach small settlement of Kikhorthang, village. After a short rest to enjoy the dramatic landscape of the valley we continue towards Tangey thru vegetable fields & orchards. Tangey Lhakhang (temple) is dedicated to Lord Buddha and its local protective deity Yeshe Gempo. The original foundation of the temple dates back to 1517 – 1554. After a thorough scanning of the temple we head back to hotel crossing a wooden bridge over the crystal clear river.

Evening at leisure .

Overnight at the Lodge in Gangtey .

DAY 06 :GANGTEY – PUNAKHA (70 KM,3 HRS)

After breakfast, drive to Punakha. The road passes through a temperate type of leafy forest where rhododendron and magnolia bloom in March and April then a semi tropical zone where orange trees, banana trees and cactuses are found in abundance.

Until 1955, Punakha served as capital of Bhutan and still it is winter seat of Je Khenpo, the Chief Abbot.

Before entering Punakha town en route take a short excursion to **Chimi Lhakhang**: Situated on a hillock in the centre of the valley, this temple is dedicated to Lama Drukpa Kuenley, who in the late 15th century used humour, songs and outrageous behaviour to dramatise his teachings and due to this also known as 'Divine Madman'. This temple is also known as the temple of fertility. It is widely believed that couples who do not have children and wanting one, if they pray at this temple, they are usually blessed with a child very soon.

After lunch, visit the **Punakha Dzong** : Built strategically at the junction of Pho Chhu and Mo Chhu rivers in 1637 by Shabdrung Ngawang Namgyal to serve as the religious and administrative centre of the region, Punakha Dzong has played an important role in Bhutan's history. Damaged by four catastrophic fires and an earthquake, the Dzong has been fully restored by Fourth King.



Later in the evening, visit **Sangchhen Dorji Lhuendrup Lhakhang nunnery**: Perched on a ridge amid pine trees and overlooking valleys of Punakha and Wangduephodrang, gleams the magnificent structures of Sangchhen Dorji Lhuendrup Lhakhang (Temple). The temple houses a 14-foot main bronze statue of Avalokiteshvara (Chenrigzigchagtongchentong). The temple complex also houses a permanent higher learning and meditation centre for nuns where, apart from religious trainings, it provides life skill training such as tailoring, embroidery, statue making and thangka painting.

Overnight at the hotel in Punakha. (Altitude 1,300m)

DAY 07 : PUNAKHA (TASHITANG VALLEY EXCURSION)

Here, at an elevation of approximately 1,400 metres, it is noticeably warmer than at most of the elevations encountered so far on the tour. As a consequence, bird activity is at its greatest in the cooler early morning.

We will spend most of the morning birding along a broad track that follows the thunderous Mo Chu River through delightful tracts of broad-leaved forest. The Mo Chu River and its stony banks and islands often harbour many of the special birds that make Himalayan rivers such a joy for birdwatchers. ***Plumbeous Redstarts and White-capped River Chats feed from boulders, Brown Dippers flash noisily up and down, Blue Whistling Thrushes look rather ungainly, and less demonstrative species such as River Lapwing, the giant Crested Kingfisher, Slaty-backed Forktail and Ibisbill*** may also be found. We will be focusing on nesting ***Ibisbill***, the very rarely observed and globally threatened ***White-bellied Heron, River Lapwing, Red-headed Trogon, Grey-headed Woodpecker, Striated Bulbul, the glowing Little Niltava, all three tesias (the Chestnut-headed is a gem), Pygmy Blue-Flycatcher, Pygmy Wren-babbler***, the infrequently seen and very striking ***Rufous-chinned Laughingthrush, Red-faced Liocichla and the stunning Scarlet Finch***. The Tashitang Valley is a truly beguiling spot, full of wonderful colours and soul enriching scenery.

In the forest we may see ***Himalayan Swiftlet, Great Himalayan, Blue-throated and Golden-throated Barbets, Greater and Lesser Yellow-naped Woodpeckers, Maroon Oriole, Ashy and Hair-crested Drongos***, and a wide variety of attractive ***Himalayan flycatchers, leaf warblers, flycatcher-warblers, nuthatches, flower peckers and sunbirds***. Among the more unusual forest species recorded here are ***Bay Woodpecker, Long-tailed Broadbill, Red-headed Trogon, White-gorgetted Flycatcher and Yellow-vented Warbler***, perhaps the most stunning of the ***leaf warblers (of the genus Phylloscopus)***.



We will then return to Punakha and later in the afternoon explore farther along the river, where we will be on the lookout for **Ibis bill and Bar-headed Geese** on the surrounding gravel beds, as well as migrants such as the lovely **Ruddy Shelduck**. This valley is an important migration conduit, and almost anything could turn up. If we are lucky, we could also see **Great Black-headed Gulls and rafts of northern ducks** en route to their breeding grounds in Tibet.

Later in the afternoon, excursion to **Talo village**, which is scattered along the hill slopes and known for its cleanliness and hygiene among Punakha villages. Talo is the seat of the mind incarnations of the Zhabdrung. Talo Sangnacholing Dzong is built on a plateau and has majestic view of surrounding villages. The beautiful farmhouses of the village have its own flower gardens and on the hill slope corns and sweet peas are grown in abundance. Spend time at Nobgang and Talo villages visiting farmhouses and meeting families, experiencing Bhutanese rural life.

Also visit **Nalanda Buddhist Institute**. Locals call this place 'Dalayna' and the monks call it Nalanda Buddhist College. The Nalanda Buddhist Institute is a monastic school near the village of Talo, above the Punatsangchu river. Here you've opportunity to interact with monks, for knowledge on Buddhism, process of meditation.

Overnight at the hotel in Punakha. (Altitude 1,300m)

DAY 08: PUNAKHA – PARO (125 KM , 4 ½ HRS):

After Breakfast drive on to Paro, the road climbs steeply through a forest of pine and cedar, festooned with hanging lichen high up near Dochula pass (3,080 m). This pass often offers panoramic views of the Himalayan Mountain ranges. After stopping for tea and the view, we descend along a series of hairpin bends to river valley.

On arrival check in at the hotel

Later in the day set out on an exploratory excursion in around Paro valley.

Paro (2,280m) - The beautiful valley of Paro encapsulates within itself a rich culture, scenic beauty and hundreds of myths and legends. It is home to many of Bhutan's oldest temples and monasteries, National Museum and the country's only airport. Mount. Chomolhari (7,314m) reigns in white glory at the northern end of the valley and its glacial water plunge through deep gorges to form Pa Chhu (Paro river). Paro is also one of the most fertile valleys in the Kingdom producing a bulk of the locally famous red rice from its terraced fields.

Visit **Ta Dzong** originally built as a watchtower, which now houses the National Museum. The extensive collection includes antique thangkha paintings, textiles, weapons & armor, household objects and a rich assortment of natural and historic artifacts.

Then walk down the trail to visit **Rinpung Dzong**, meaning ("fortress of the heap of jewels"), which has a long and fascinating history. Along the wooden galleries lining the inner courtyard are fine wall

paintings illustrating Buddhist lore such as four friends, the old man of long life, the wheel of life, scenes from the life of Milarepa, Mount. Sumeru and other cosmic Mandala.

Evening exploratory walk on the market streets of Paro. Overnight at the hotel in Paro.

DAY 09 :PARO - TIGER’S NEST HIKE

After breakfast, drive to newly restored **Drukgyal Dzong**: It was here that the Bhutanese finally defeated the invading Tibetans and drove them back. Peak of Jumolhari ‘Mountain of the Goddess’ can be seen on a clear day from here (7,329 mts/24,029 ft.).



The valley of Paro is mainly Blue Pine Forests not so favourable for bird life but the woodlands around the Drukgyel Dzong area will provide us a good indication of the great variety that is to come in the next few days. Some of the common species that can be seen in this area include, ***Black-faced laughing thrush, Chestnut-crowned laughing thrush, Brown Parrot bill, Chestnut-tailed Minla, Common Kestrel, Kalij Pheasant, White-collared Blackbird, Grey-backed Shrike***. The more elusive birds that we may just locate are some marshland species such as the ***Black-tailed Crake and the Solitary Snipe***.

Later, we will enjoy an excursion to **Taktsang Monastery (Tiger’s Nest)**, one of the holiest monasteries in Bhutan, which was burnt down in 1988 but is now fully restored. Birds that can be seen in the valley here include ***Blue Whistling Thrush, Hodgson’s and Blue-fronted Redstart, Hoopoe, Rufous Sibia, White-collared Blackbird, Rufous-breasted Accentor, Long-tailed and Grey-backed Shrikes, and Yellow-billed Blue Magpie***.

Taktsang, the 'Tiger's Nest' Monastery, appears to cling magically to the sheer rock face 915 metres above the valley. Legend has it that the Guru Padmasambhava, riding a flying tiger, landed on the cliff when he came from Tibet in the 8th century. There he, and later his follower Dubthok Singye, meditated in a cave around which, 300 years ago, the monastery was built to celebrate his arrival. We will take our time here and are likely to spend most of the time in this wonderful setting and its surrounding forests. On our way up, we will make regular birding stops while enjoying the scenery.

Overnight at the hotel in Paro. (Altitude 2,280m)

DAY 10 : PARO/CHELALA PASS FOR BIRDING:

(One way- 45 kms, approx 1 hr drive)

We will set off after early breakfast for the long drive up to the impressive Chele La pass on the road to Haa, which at a breathtaking 3,780 metres is an excellent spot for seeing the spectacular Himalayan Monal. This must be one of the most colourful and strikingly patterned of all the world's many pheasants. We hope to see the adult male at relatively close range as it shows off its iridescent blue, indigo, green and black plumage. It is an extraordinary experience to see one flying off, displaying its white back patch, and uttering its wild, ringing cry, and is a spectacle that seems to epitomise high Himalayan birding. Typical species here include Eurasian Sparrowhawk, Grey Nightjar, Yellow-billed Blue Magpie, Spotted (or Eurasian) Nutcracker, Long-tailed Minivet, Coal, Grey-crested and Rufous-fronted Tits, Black-faced Laughingthrush, White-browed Fulvetta, Rufous-vented Yuhina, Rufous-gorgeted Flycatcher, Buff-barred Warbler, Red-flanked Bluetail, Blue-fronted Redstart, Long-tailed Thrush, White-collared Blackbird, Mrs Gould's Sunbird, Oliver-backed Pipit, the huge Collared Grosbeak, White-winged Grosbeak, and White-browed and Dark-rumped Rosefinches. With a bit of luck, we will find some Altai Accentors lingering in their winter quarters.

From Chele La we will travel by road for a couple of hours back to Paro, with some birding stops en route. Then it will be time for a well-deserved rest!

PS: Lunch will be packed lunch today.

Overnight at the hotel in Paro (Altitude 2200m).

DAY 11 : DEPART PARO

After an early breakfast at the hotel, drive to the airport for the flight to your onward destination. Our representative will help you with exit formalities and then bid you farewell.

BHUTAN BIRDING TOUR - 2

DAY 01: ARRIVAL IN PARO- THIMPHU (1.5 HRS)

On arrival in Paro International Airport. We welcome with khaddar and proceed to Thimphu which will take about an hour and half. The route will follow Paro River until Chuzom from where we will bend towards Thimphu River taking us to the heart of capital city Thimphu. The entire stretch of drives is very scenic and picturesque as we pass by some of the beautiful villages of Bondey, Shaba, Isina etc until we enter welcome gate in Thimphu. **Tachongang Lhakhang**- En-route to Thimphu, stopover for little leg stretch walk crossing Paro River or enjoy the views from the roadside depending your arrival time. Chuzom- Meeting point of two rivers (Thimphu & Paro) this is tri junction of highway leading to Thimphu, Paro and Phuentsholing into three directions. Enjoy the lovely picture of beautiful portrait our King and Queen placed at chuzom which is so welcoming to all who visits Bhutan.

Overnight in Thimphu, altitude 2400m

DAY 02: THIMPHU- TSIRANG (5 HRS)

The route from Thimphu to Tsirang is quite scenic; **Buddha Dordenma** - The Buddha Dordenma is located at a top of the hill in **Kuenselphodrang Nature Park** and overlooks the southern entrance to Thimphu valley. **Dochula Pass** – The pass is at a popular location as it offers a stunning 180 degree panoramic view of the Great Himalayan mountain ranges. The view is especially scenic and very clear on winter days with snowcapped mountains forming a majestic backdrop to the tranquility of the 108 chortens gracing the mountain pass. The valley of black necked cranes and rhododendron and often referred as Asian Switzerland. Bird watching at **Lamperi Botanical Garden** – The Royal Botanical Park is the country's first nature recreational park, to preserve the rich natural biodiversity of the area. You will be able to spot some rare Himalayan birds such as Great Parrotbill, Darjeeling woodpecker, streak-breasted scimitar babbler, eurasian jay, strong-footed bush warbler, chestnut-crowned and spotted laughing thrushes. **Rigsum Pemai Dumra** – This recreational park is located in the Heart of the Damphu town. The park serves as a rejuvenating getaway for many tired souls, and also promises to offer you the chance to develop an intimate connection with nature.

Overnight in Tsirang, altitude 2000m

DAY 03: TSIRANG SIGHTSEEING- GELEPHU (3 HRS)

Tsirang District is located in the southwestern part of Bhutan on the Wangdue-Gelephu highway. Tsirang is noted for its gentle slopes and mild climates. The dzongkhag is also noted for its rich biodiversity; however, it is one of the few dzongkhags without a protected area. Tsirang is one of the fastest developing dzongkhags in Bhutan. Explore villages of Tsirang– Today we will explore the beautiful valley

and meet with the farmers. Drive to Gelephu. **Farm House Visit-** To reach this village, you need to drive for 4 hours from Sarpang. This experience is a particularly fun and spontaneous way to connect with the local community of Southern valley and learn about their culture and way of living. Overnight in Gelephu, altitude 450m

DAY 04: GELEPHU- MANAS (3.5 HRS)

Enjoy the scenic drive towards Manas. **Gelephu Tshachu– Gelephu Tshachu** is a popular hot spring and wondrous tourist destination in the spiritual kingdom of Bhutan. Dip yourself in the hot and sparkling waters of the Gelephu Tshachu. Roadside sightseeing: The drive towards Manas will pass through dense jungles full of golden langurs and various bird watching including hornbills. Continue the drive towards South to Manas.

Overnight in Manas,

DAY 05: MANAS - SAFARI

Manas National park safari.

River Rafting at Manas US\$ 120 lump sum from 01 – 05 Pax per hour.

DAY 06: MANAS- TINGTIBI (5 HRS DRIVE)

The road towards Manas is mix of bumpy and smooth road. Tingtibi is an area much sought after by bird watchers from across the world. The place is also home to the critically endangered white-bellied heron. Duenmang Tshachu/hot spring- This healing spring is famous for curing joint pains, sinusitis, gastric, rheumatism and tuberculosis. It takes 45 min- 1 hour to reach the tshachu from the road. Bird Watching in Tingtibi– Tingtibi is recognized as a potential area for bird watching because of large number of native bird species found there. Some of the birds seen are it serves as nice habitat for Rufous-necked and Great Hornbills, varieties of Cool Laughing Thrushes, Cutias, Scarlet Minivets, Pin-tailed Green Pigeons, Woodpeckers, Chestnut-headed, Grey-bellied Tesias, Spotted Wren Babblers, etc. Overnight in Tingtibi.

DAY 07: TINGTIBI- PHOBJIKHA (5.5 HRS)

You will have another round of birding in the morning and then drive back to Phobjikha with birding along the way. The natural beauty of the Phobjikha, beautiful home stays and nature adds more value to experience the living style, food habit and culture of the Bhutanese people. **Kuenga Rabten Palace–** During the first half of the 20th century, the palace served as winter residence for the second King, Jigme Wangchuck and his senior Queen, Ashi Phuntsho Choden. Due to this heritage, the Kuenga Rabten Palace is surrounded by stone walls that have spy-holes, which were used by the royal guards. Chendebji Chorten: Located at 2430m, built in the style of the great Bodhanath Temple of Nepal, and was constructed by Tshering Wangchuk son of Yon-Say and the Mahasiddha Zhidag in accordance with the prophecy of the second Gangteng Tulku Tenzin Lekpai Dhundrup in order to subdue harmful demons. Overnight at hotel in Phobjikha.

DAY 08: PHOBJIKHA – PUNAKHA (4.5 HRS)

After breakfast check out from the hotel and visit **Black Necked Crane Information Centre-** This place is run by the Royal Society for Protection of Nature (RSPN) and has an observation room with high-power

telescopes and good scope for spotting the famous Black Necked Cranes which migrates to the region during winter. It also displays information ab2900m.

Later continue drive to Punakha, upon arrival; check into the hotel. Later visit **Punakha Dzong**, a massive structure built at the junction of two rivers. It was the capital of Bhutan until 1955, and still serves as the winter residence of the monk body.

Excursion to **Chimi Lhakhang** (from hotel it is about 15 minutes' drive till motorable road and then walk starts through paddy fields and villages. This is total about 1½ hour walk, including both way). The Chimi Lhakhang, situated on a hillock in the centre of the valley, also known as the temple of fertility. It is widely believed that couples who do not have children and wanting one, if they pray at this temple, they are usually blessed with a child very soon. The trail leads across rice fields to the tiny settlement of Pana, meaning 'field'. A walk through the village near the temple will give you rare glimpses into the daily life and lifestyle of the villagers

Overnight at Hotel in Punakha.

DAY 09: PUNAKHA - PARO (4 HRS)

As we proceed to Paro, we will retrace the journey crossing over Dochula, up until Chuzom and further to Paro. The entire stretch of drive will refresh your mind and give you second chance to enjoy the great snowcapped mountain views of the Himalayas from Dochula. Paro Town- Tiny Paro town actually can offer lot more, there are many authentic handicraft shops, readily available Bhutan made products, grocery and imported garment shops beside having many small restaurants around. **Rinpung Dzong**- 'Fortress on a Heap of Jewels', is ranked one of the best Bhutanese architecture. The massive buttressed walls that tower over the town are visible throughout the valley, particularly when landing at Paro Airport. The Dzong also offers administrative seat of the district of Paro. The Dzong was built in 1644 under the order of Zhabdrung Ngawang Namgyal. National Museum of Paro- Perched above Paro Dzong it was watchtower built in 1649 to protect the undefended **Paro Dzong** located below, renovated in 1968 to house the **National Museum**. Today this museum houses the best collections of all time historical items making worth for a visit.

Overnight in Paro, altitude 2200m

DAY 10: PARO SIGHTSEEING

This picturesque region in the kingdom is covered in fertile rice fields and has a beautiful, crystalline river meandering down the valley. Paro has more of historical sites, high-end tourist resort and many souvenir shops for shopping including world famous Takstang. **Taktsang Gompa/Tiger's Nest Temple**— is Bhutan's most iconic landmark and religious Buddhist site in the world. The name Taktsang translates to "The Tiger's Nest". The temple is one of the holiest sites in Bhutan which clings impossibly to a sheer cliff face 900 meters above the valley. Although good trekkers can make it to the top in two hours, most of the guests take whole day to complete the hike. Outdoor Activities- Nicely made and well maintained activity place attached to whole sell Buddha statue store, offers wearing Bhutanese dress, playing archery and darts for guests visiting Bhutan. The center is maintained and operated by HBT herself and its free of cost for all HBT guests.

Overnight in Paro

DAY 11: END OF THE TOUR

Departure from the Kingdom of Bhutan

Bhutan Birding Tour - 3

DAY 1: ARRIVE PARO

Upon arrival meet & greet at Paro Airport, then transfer to your hotel. Later Birding around Paro. Birds we may encounter include Ibisbill, River Lapwing, Grey-backed Shrike, Oriental Turtle Dove, Rufous-breasted Accentor, Hodgson's Redstart and perhaps Black-tailed Crake. Sightseeing in Paro. Overnight at Hotel.

DAY 2: PARO- THIMPU (1.5 HRS)

We spend the morning birding at Chele La Pass. This is a good location for Himalayan Monal. Blood and Kalij Pheasant may be sighted here. Other possibilities include Yellow-billed Blue Magpie, Grey-crested & Rufous-fronted Tits, Black-faced Laughingthrush, Long-tailed Thrush, White-collared Blackbird, Collared Grosbeak, White-browed and Dark-rumped Rosefinch. Later we drive to Thimphu (2240m) with birding stops along the way. Sightseeing in Thimphu. Overnight at Hotel.

DAY 3: THIMPU- GANGTEY (3.5 HRS)

We will depart for Gangtey with stops en route as we climb towards Dochu La Pass. In the afternoon we leave the central highway, and we will walk from a point near the Gadgety La pass at 3358m down into the Phobjika valley. The valley is the winter home for Black-necked Cranes, but sightings depend on the time of our visit. We will visit Gangtey Gompa and spend the night at Gangtey in a Hotel

DAY 4: GANGTEY-BUMTHANG (5.5 HRS)

In the morning we depart for Pele La (3412m) and take a birding walk down the old road (3375-3000m), stopping for a picnic lunch. Birds found in the area include Himalayan Griffon, Chestnut-bellied Rock Thrush, Grey-sided Bush-warbler and Fire-tailed Sunbird. Later we drive to Trongsa situated at 2290m and We ascend Yotong La (3275m) and bird down from summit depending on time. Birds found here include Slender-billed Scimitar-babbler, Great Parrotbill, Fulvous Parrotbill, Red-headed Bullfinch, White-winged Grosbeak, Gold-naped Finch. After birding we will visit a hand-made textile centre in Chumi valley. Overnight in Bumthang.

DAY 5: BUMTHANG-SENGOR (4.5 HRS)

This morning we head over Shertang La (3418m) and thence through the Ura valley (2800-2900m), and up Thrumsing La (3757m), and finally down to the Sengor campsite situated at an elevation of 3000m. Amongst other species we will hope to find Blood Pheasant, Satyr Tragopan, Fire-tailed Myzornis, Fire-tailed Sunbird and Great Parrotbill. Overnight at Sengor.

DAY 6: SENSOR

Another day birding in the Sengor area. Overnight at Sengor Camp.

DAY 7: SENGOR-YONGKHOLA (1.5 HRS)

Birding down the famed Lingmethang road from Sengor camp past Namling to Yongkhola campsite at 1535m. In the next three days we will hope to find Ward's Trogon, Rufous-necked Hornbill, Satyr Tragopan, Blue-fronted Robin, Greater Rufous-headed Parrotbill, Rusty-fronted Barwing, Rufous-throated Wren-babbler, Coral-billed Scimitar-babbler, Slender-billed Scimitar-babbler, Broad-billed Warbler, Black-throated Parrotbill. With luck we will find Sikkim Wedge-billed, Long-billed or Bar-winged Wren-babblers. Other bird species found in the area include Asian Emerald Cuckoo, Blue-bearded Bee-eater, Crimson-breasted Woodpecker, Streak-breasted and Rusty-cheeked Scimitar-babblers, Bhutan Laughingthrush, Golden-breasted Fulvetta, Sapphire Flycatcher, White-browed and Lesser Shortwings, Black-headed Shrike-babbler, Crimson-browed Finch and hopefully (!) much more. Overnight at Yongkhola.

DAY 8: YONGKHOLA-TRASHIGANG (5 HRS)

A Long drive takes us to Trashigang with birding enroute. We will make birding stops en-route. Species might include Grey-winged Blackbird, Brown-throated Treecreeper, Grey-sided Laughingthrush and Little Bunting. Overnight at Trashigang.

DAY 9: TRASHIGANG-MORONG (4 HRS)

Morning Sightseeing and long drive to Samrudjonkar. Overnight in Morong.

DAY 10: MORONG-GUWAHATI (7 HRS)

The morning is spent birding around Deothang, and then between Samdrup Jongkhar (250m) and Deothang (850m). A wide variety of birds might include Black Eagle, Emerald Dove, Bronzed Drongo, Green-billed Malkoha, Great and Oriental Pied Hornbills, Black-crested Bulbul, Grey-throated Babbler, Black-naped Monarch, Blue-winged Laughingthrush, Orange-bellied Leafbird, Red-faced Liocichla, Red-billed Leiothrix and with luck Beautiful Nuthatch.

Depart at noon for Guwahati, India.

*****END OF THE TOUR*****